the plan was to stick to our assigned tasks calmly and not to try to rush out and score too quickly.

But – and this is the part I find so flipping bizarre – we did *exactly* the opposite. Our top order went bananas, trying to blast the Aussies, and within no time at all we were 27/5. And that was pretty much it. Game over. Graeme Smith, AB de Villiers, Ashwell Prince, Mark Boucher – all gone.

You simply don't recover from that position when you are up against Australia. I remember thinking while I was batting: 'No man, I can't believe the guys actually did that!' I knew the damage had been done, but I just couldn't figure out what had happened to our supposed game plan. I couldn't understand why the batsmen had just changed their minds entirely. I scratched around with Justin Kemp, getting 39, and Kempie was not out on 49 for a miserable total of 149 in 43.5 overs. Predictably, the Aussies took no prisoners, overtaking our total inside of 32 overs.

Whether or not our guys were carrying the scars from previous World Cups, I don't know. But to me it looked like we had just plain panicked. Our performance could only have been the result of not being able to handle the pressure of being in a major semi-final. When it comes to big-match temperament, you can have the most experienced guys in your team, but in these situations, even they can't handle the pressure.

And did we sit down and analyse our (lack of) performance after the game? Nope, no discussion at all. When I got out and returned to the dressing room, Jacques' bag was already packed and he was sitting there reading a magazine, while our innings was grounding to a complete halt. I kept on looking over at Mickey, and he seemed as bewildered by what was happening as I was. The guys looked like they were just relieved that the pressure was finally off, that the whole thing was over and that we could now go home. Weird.

The only thought going through my head was, 'No … not *again*.' Maybe if there had been more of a team spirit in the squad I might have stood up and said something, or shook Mickey by the shoulders.

When we got back to the hotel, it was a case of, 'Well, everything's good now. At least we're on our way back to South Africa.' I, on the other hand, felt pretty sad and empty as I left the West Indies that year.

Unsurprisingly, the label 'chokers' was pinned on our jerseys by the world media, and I'm finding it increasingly tough to float a counter-argument. If a team cannot handle the pressure, then they are chokers. And